



HONEY HARVEST, VARROA AWARENESS AND MID-SUMMER MANAGEMENT

July sits at the heart of the beekeeping season. Colonies are often at or near peak strength, supers may be heavy with honey and many beekeepers begin planning or carrying out their first honey harvests of the year.

While swarm pressure is generally lower than during May and June, it has not disappeared completely. Strong colonies, older queens and congested hives can still produce queen cells and attempt to swarm.

July is a month of balance. Honey production, colony health, swarm awareness and preparation for late-summer management all begin to overlap.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL TIMING (JULY IN THE UK)

July is typically one of the warmest months of the year in the UK. Long daylight hours and favourable temperatures allow colonies to forage extensively when nectar sources are available.

Many colonies take advantage of forage such as clover, bramble, lime trees and a wide range of garden flowers. However, local conditions can vary significantly, and some areas may experience temporary forage gaps or drought conditions.

Large populations require significant resources. Colonies may still maintain substantial brood nests while simultaneously storing surplus honey.

Inspections remain important, but care should be taken during periods of extreme heat to minimise unnecessary disruption.

REALITY CHECK : A heavy super does not automatically mean it is ready for extraction.

WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

By July, most colonies have reached maximum or near-maximum population levels.

Foraging activity is often intense, with thousands of workers gathering nectar, pollen, water and propolis daily. Brood rearing continues, although some colonies may begin to reduce expansion later in the month.



The colony is now focused on:

- Gathering and storing surplus honey
- Maintaining brood production
- Supporting a large worker population
- Preparing for seasonal changes later in the year

This is often the point where strong colonies demonstrate the results of good spring management.

WHAT YOU SHOULD BE DOING IN JULY

July is about managing abundance while remaining vigilant.

Key priorities include:

- Monitoring supers and honey stores
- Continuing inspections
- Watching for late swarm activity
- Monitoring colony health
- Assessing varroa levels
- Maintaining accurate records

Many beekeepers become focused solely on honey production during July. However, colony health and preparation for the months ahead remain equally important.

REALITY CHECK : Large populations can sometimes hide developing health problems.

INSPECTIONS – STAYING AWARE

Inspection frequency may begin to reduce slightly compared with peak swarm season, but colonies should still be monitored regularly.

Many beekeepers inspect every 7–10 days, depending on local conditions and colony behaviour.



Inspection priorities include:

- Confirming colonies remain queenright
- Assessing brood quality
- Monitoring honey stores
- Checking for queen cells
- Identifying disease symptoms
- Evaluating colony temperament

Even colonies that appear settled should not be ignored.

SWARM FOLLOW-UP – NOT QUITE FINISHED

Although swarm pressure often reduces during July, it should never be assumed that swarming has completely ended.

Colonies with older queens or those experiencing congestion may still attempt to swarm.

Pay particular attention to:

- Queen cells
- Queen performance
- Colony congestion
- Recent swarm history

Late-season swarms can significantly reduce colony strength ahead of autumn.

PRACTICAL RULE: Never stop looking for queen cells simply because the calendar says July.

HONEY FLOW & SUPER MANAGEMENT

July is frequently associated with honey production.

Many colonies are storing significant quantities of nectar and supers can become heavy surprisingly quickly during strong flows.

Regular checks should be made to assess:

- Super occupancy
- Available storage space
- Honey ripeness
- Extraction planning
- Ongoing nectar flow



Additional supers should still be provided where required. Running out of space can create unnecessary congestion.

When planning extraction, only harvest honey that has been properly ripened and is suitable for removal.

HONEY HARVEST PLANNING

For many beekeepers, July marks the beginning of honey harvesting.

Signs that honey may be ready include:

- Capped honey cells
- Heavy supers
- Fully ripened honey
- Minimal nectar content

Extraction should be planned carefully, with suitable equipment and storage available before supers are removed.

Removing honey too early can create problems with moisture content and storage quality.

REALITY CHECK: The best time to prepare for extraction is before the supers are ready, not after.

COMB REPLACEMENT & FRAME MANAGEMENT

July remains a useful time for reviewing comb condition and hive equipment.

Identify:

- Old brood comb
- Damaged frames
- Equipment requiring maintenance
- Future replacement requirements

While major manipulations may be avoided during strong nectar flows, July provides an excellent opportunity to plan future comb rotation.

Strong colonies can still draw foundation where conditions remain favourable.

HEALTH, DISEASE & VARROA MONITORING

July is a critical month for colony health monitoring.

Large colonies can mask developing issues, making careful observation essential.



Look for:

- Patchy brood patterns
- Sunken cappings
- Discoloured larvae
- Deformed wings
- Unusual smells
- Declining colony strength

Varroa monitoring should be an important part of July management.

Information gathered now helps shape treatment decisions later in summer and early autumn.

PRACTICAL RULE: If you do not know your varroa levels, you are making decisions without important information.

FOOD & STORES

Although nectar flows are often strong during July, food shortages can still occur.

Weather changes, forage gaps and recent swarms can all affect colony food reserves.

Continue monitoring:

- Hive weight
- Nectar availability
- Colony strength
- Food stores

Strong colonies can consume significant quantities of food, particularly during periods of poor weather.

APIARY & EQUIPMENT MANAGEMENT

July is a practical management month.

Ensure:

- Extraction equipment is ready
- Spare supers remain available
- Water sources are maintained
- Vegetation remains controlled
- Hive stands remain stable

Good organisation makes honey harvesting and inspections significantly easier.



RECORD KEEPING

July generates a large amount of useful information.

Records should include:

- Inspection dates
- Honey harvests
- Super additions and removals
- Queen status
- Swarm activity
- Varroa monitoring results
- Health observations

Accurate records help inform management decisions throughout autumn and winter.

JULY TAKEAWAY

July is about managing productive colonies while preparing for the transition into late summer.

Honey harvests may be underway, but colony health, varroa awareness and ongoing inspections remain just as important as honey production.

Successful July management comes from maintaining strong colonies, monitoring health carefully and making decisions based on observations rather than assumptions.

REALITY CHECK: The colonies producing the most honey are not always the colonies in the best long-term health.



JULY APIARY CHECKLIST

Honey Harvest • Varroa Awareness • Mid-Summer Management

- ☐ **Inspect colonies every 7–10 days**
- ☐ **Confirm the colony is queenright**
- ☐ **Check for late-season queen cells**
- ☐ **Assess brood pattern and queen performance**
- ☐ **Monitor colony temperament**
- ☐ **Ensure sufficient space by adding supers if required**
- ☐ **Check supers for capped, ripened honey**
- ☐ **Plan or carry out honey extraction when appropriate**
- ☐ **Avoid harvesting unripe honey**
- ☐ **Monitor Varroa levels (record mite counts)**
- ☐ **Watch for signs of disease or pests**
- ☐ **Check food stores and hive weight**
- ☐ **Ensure a clean water source is available nearby**
- ☐ **Keep grass and vegetation around hives under control**
- ☐ **Inspect hive stands, roofs and straps**
- ☐ **Replace damaged frames or note combs for replacement**
- ☐ **Clean and prepare extraction equipment**
- ☐ **Record inspections, honey harvests and Varroa results**
- ☐ **Review each colony and identify any needing extra attention**